Lesson 22: Executive Order 9066: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 6.1: Discussion; 6.2: Listening-Why I Love a Country That Once Betrayed Me; 6.3: Reading-Japanese Relocation During World War II; 16.5: Chapter 5 (audio transcript).

In this lesson

You will watch George Takei's TED talk "Why I Love a Country That Once Betrayed Me" and read "Japanese Relocation During World War II", about Executive Order 9066 and the internment of Japanese Americans during World War II. You will answer central idea questions, work out the meaning of a word from context, and notice how word choice shows a writer's point of view, an important skill for reading academic texts. The reading is also the base for the next lesson on the passive voice.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what Executive Order 9066 was, why it was issued and whom it affected.
- Retell the main events of George Takei's childhood and the story of the 442nd Regimental Combat Team.
- Choose the central idea of a text and the evidence for it, and work out the meaning of a new word from context.
- Compare how different people describe the camps.
- Use new words such as internment, ancestry, espionage, dissident and due process.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
internment (n); internee (n)	putting people in a camp, usually in wartime, without a trial; an internee is a person in such a camp	The internment of persons of Japanese ancestry during World War II sparked constitutional and political debate.
executive order (n)	an order from the U.S. president that has the force of law	President Roosevelt ... issued Executive Order 9066.
ancestry, descent (n)	the people and the country that your family comes from	all persons of Japanese ancestry, both citizens and aliens
alien (n)	a person who lives in a country but is not a citizen of it	whether citizens or enemy aliens

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
espionage (n)	spying: secretly getting information for an enemy	The objectives of the order were to prevent espionage ...
assembly center / relocation center (n)	a temporary camp near people's homes / a permanent camp far inland	Soon they were sent to permanent relocation centers.
barracks (n)	simple buildings for soldiers; in the camps, families lived in them	shared barracks made of tar paper
dissident (n)	a person who protests against the government or its rules	where dissidents were housed
hysteria (n)	extreme fear or excitement that people cannot control	America suddenly was swept up by hysteria.
due process (n)	the legal steps that protect a person's rights, such as charges and a trial	with no charges, with no trial, with no due process
constitutional (adj); constitutionality (n)	allowed by the Constitution, the highest law of the U.S.; being allowed by it	They challenged the constitutionality of the relocation and curfew orders.
patriotism (n)	love of your country and loyalty to it	Their military record reflected their patriotism.
injustice (n)	unfair treatment	Congress ... acknowledged the injustice of the internment.
irony (n)	a situation that is the opposite of what you expect	One of the most stunning ironies in this episode ...

Rules and explanations

The talk

- George Takei is an actor from the TV series Star Trek ("I'm a veteran of the starship Enterprise"). His mother was born in Sacramento, California, his father was from San Francisco, and George was born in Los Angeles.
- He was four years old when Pearl Harbor was bombed on December 7, 1941. A few weeks after his fifth birthday, soldiers ordered his family out of their home. They traveled by train for four days and three nights to a camp in the swamps of Arkansas.
- After the war, the family was released with a one-way ticket. They were penniless and lived first on Skid Row in Los Angeles.
- As a teenager, he talked with his father about American democracy: "a people's democracy", which "can be as great as the people can be, but it is also as fallible as people are."
- Young Japanese Americans who volunteered for the army were first refused and called "enemy non-alien". Later, thousands went from the camps to fight. The 442nd broke a six-month stalemate

on the Gothic Line in 32 minutes and came home as the most decorated unit of the Second World War.

The reading: key facts

"Japanese Relocation During World War II" (CommonLit) has 10 numbered paragraphs.

When	What happened
December 7, 1941	Japan attacked Pearl Harbor, and the United States entered the war fully.
February 1942	President Roosevelt issued Executive Order 9066. All persons of Japanese ancestry on the West Coast were moved inland. The stated objectives: to prevent espionage and to protect them from Americans with anti-Japanese attitudes.
1942	117,000 people were affected; two-thirds were U.S. citizens. The Issei were the first generation in the U.S.; the Nisei, the second. People went first to assembly centers (for example, a fairground), then to relocation centers such as Manzanar and Tule Lake.
1943-1944	The government formed the 442d Regimental Combat Team, the most highly decorated unit of World War II.
1944	In Ex parte Mitsuye Endo, the Supreme Court ruled that Endo was entitled to an unconditional release.
1988	Public Law 100-383 acknowledged the injustice, apologized and gave $20,000 to each person who was interned.

Words show a point of view

- The reading mostly uses the official words of the time: relocation, assembly center, relocation center, internment. It also reports two views: "Some people refer to the relocation centers as concentration camps; others view internment as an unfortunate episode, but a military necessity."
- Takei uses stronger words: "rounded up", "imprisoned", "barbed-wire prison camps".
- When you read history, ask: Which words does the writer choose, and what do they show about the writer's view?

Central idea and words in context

- The central idea must fit the whole text, including its ending. Then choose the quotation that proves it best.
- To find the meaning of a new word, read the whole sentence and look for a clue word near it. Then put each option into the sentence and check that the meaning still works.

Practice

Discussion (before you watch). Answer aloud to your tutor or record yourself. Then write a post (see "Writing task").

1. What historical events have prompted fear of others?

2. Why do people hate others who are not like them?

Exercise 1: Listening comprehension. Watch the talk first, without the transcript: https://www.ted.com/talks/george_takei_why_i_love_a_country_that_once_betrayed_me. Answer the questions. Then read the transcript at the end of the lesson material and check.

1. Why were Takei and his family relocated to an internment camp?
    - a) They were not loyal to America.
    - b) They had recently immigrated from Japan.
    - c) They were of Japanese descent.
    - d) They did not support the war.
2. Which of the following describes Takei's experiences in the internment camp?
    - a) He thought it was normal.
    - b) He felt betrayed by his country.
    - c) He blamed his parents for his internment.
    - d) He understood he was being treated differently.
3. How were Japanese Americans treated when they volunteered for the army?
    - a) They were slapped across the face.
    - b) They were viewed as heroes.
    - c) They were accused of being spies.
    - d) They were treated as if they were non-citizens.
4. Why did Japanese Americans volunteer to fight in the war?
    - a) They wanted to prove they could be trusted.
    - b) They wanted to fight for what America stood for.
    - c) They needed to make money to send to their families.
    - d) They wanted to bring the war and internment to an end.

Exercise 2: Reading comprehension. Read "Japanese Relocation During World War II" in the lesson material. Then answer.

1. PART A: Which statement identifies the central idea of the text?
    - a) The internment of Japanese Americans was mainly for their protection against discriminatory citizens.
    - b) While internment was said to be for the protection of Japanese Americans, they were denied constitutional rights and treated like enemy prisoners.
    - c) Japanese American internment was necessary to ensure the national security of the United States.
    - d) It wasn't until Japanese Americans participated in WWII that they earned back the right to be viewed as citizens rather than potential spies.

2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A?
    - a) "eating in common facilities and having limited opportunities for work interrupted other social and cultural patterns." (Paragraph 6)
    - b) "In 1943 and 1944 the government assembled a combat unit of Japanese Americans for the European theater. It became the 442d Regimental Combat Team and gained fame as the most highly decorated of World War II." (Paragraph 7)
    - c) "Some people refer to the relocation centers as concentration camps; others view internment as an unfortunate episode, but a military necessity." (Paragraph 9)
    - d) "'If we were put there for our protection, why were the guns at the guard towers pointed inward, instead of outward?'" (Paragraph 10)
3. PART A: What is a "dissident" as it is referred to in paragraph 6? a) protestor b) victim c) prisoner d) advocate
4. PART B: Which quote from the text best supports the answer to Part A?
    - a) "persons of Japanese ancestry in western Washington State" (Paragraph 5)
    - b) "four or five families with their sparse collections of clothing and possessions" (Paragraph 6)
    - c) "Persons who became troublesome" (Paragraph 6)
    - d) "a combat unit of Japanese Americans" (Paragraph 7)

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the two discussion questions from Lesson 22, one at a time, with follow-up questions. Correct my past tenses."
- "I will retell George Takei's story in eight sentences: before the camp, in the camp and after the war. Check my facts."
- "Quiz me on the timeline of Executive Order 9066: 1941, 1942, 117,000, 1943-1944, 1944, 1988 and $20,000. I will explain each one."
- "Let's discuss the internee's question at the end of the reading: 'If we were put there for our protection, why were the guns at the guard towers pointed inward?' Ask me what it shows and why it is ironic."
- "Explain why options a, c and d in Exercise 2, question 1, are wrong."

Read aloud

- The objectives of the order were to prevent espionage. (ES·pi·o·nage)
- Persons of Japanese ancestry were ordered to assembly centers near their homes. (AN·ces·try)
- America suddenly was swept up by hysteria. (hys·TER·i·a)
- The internment of persons of Japanese ancestry sparked constitutional and political debate. (in·TERN·ment, con·sti·TU·tion·al)
- I will never be able to forget that scene.
- You fought not only the enemy but prejudice, and you won. (PREJ·u·dice)

Writing task

Write a discussion post of 150-200 words that answers the two discussion questions.

- Start with a sentence that gives your main answer.
- Give one example from this lesson (Executive Order 9066) and one from another time or place.
- Use the simple past for history and the simple present for general ideas (People often fear …).
- Use at least four words from the Key language table.

Checklist:

- Are your facts about Executive Order 9066 correct? Check the dates and numbers against the reading.
- Did you use the simple past for past events (issued, moved, fought)?
- Did you use the simple present for general truths?
- Did you use capital letters for names and nationalities (Japanese Americans, Pearl Harbor, Executive Order 9066)?
- Did you explain why, not only what (because, so, as a result)?
- Did you use at least four new words correctly?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Why I Love a Country That Once Betrayed Me, by George Takei (TED; the listening for Exercise 1): https://www.ted.com/talks/george_takei_why_i_love_a_country_that_once_betrayed_me

Answer key

Discussion. (example answer)

1. The attack on Pearl Harbor in 1941 created fear of Japanese Americans, although most of them were U.S. citizens. Wars and terrorist attacks often make people afraid of a whole group.
2. People often fear what they do not know. Leaders and the news can also spread hysteria, as Takei says happened in America after Pearl Harbor, and fear can turn into hate.

Exercise 1. (book)

1. c. Takei: "simply because we happened to look like the people that bombed Pearl Harbor" (01:56)
2. a. "What would be grotesquely abnormal became my normality" (05:23)
3. d. "We were denied service, and categorized as enemy non-alien." (09:37)
4. b. "because they cherished the very ideal of what our government stands for" (11:01)

Exercise 2. (book)

1. b. The text gives the official reason (protection), but it ends with the guards' guns pointed inward, and it reports the court case and the 1988 apology.
2. d. The internee's question shows that the camps were like prisons, not protection.
3. a (protestor).
4. c. "Persons who became troublesome" is the clue: dissidents were people who caused trouble for the authorities by protesting.

My notes